

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS** / AI

TAKEAWAYS

- More than blue-collar jobs, what AI threatens to replace is highly skilled and creative workers
- In its current form, AI can be a decent assistant, a co-pilot that helps creators with secondary tasks
- AI-generated stories can feed the 'content' pipeline, but may not make us feel connected to humanity

were not aiming to replicate blue-collar jobs but highly skilled professionals. The Hollywood writers' strike brought up the use of AI for writing stories. Similar concerns are rife in the Indian writers' community too. At the same time, I know many independent filmmakers dabbling in AI; it doesn't just enable them to do their work quicker but also makes that 'one-man army' stronger. I recently saw a pitch deck for a mythological story where all the pictures were created by Midjourney, an AI tool.

What tasks must be human, and what must be outsourced to machines? In the context of art, that is a great question. Can storytellers and painters be machines? What does a human bring to a painting or a story?

We, humans, began telling stories when we still lived in the caves. There, in the shadows, we huddled around a fireplace with the warmth of shared tales and gossip. It was a ritual that whispered to us, reassuringly, that we were not wandering alone in the dark. Storytelling transcended time and space and wove our individual narratives into a collective tapestry, making us an integral part of our shared humanity.

But the landscape of a good story has shifted. Somewhere in recent times, stories became 'content', a ceaseless pipeline flowing into our homes, where we consume it in the distracted hum of daily life. Finish one, and our eyes immediately search for the next piece. To be fair, some of these stories manage to break free from the monotony and emerge as beacons, prompting us to sit up and take notice. Yet, a large number find themselves slipping into a genre we have come to call ambient TV—a realm where movies and series become the equivalent of elevator music, a soothing backdrop to the noise of our routines.

Will plots conceived by ChatGPT make for good ambient viewing, the minimum criterion for a content pipeline? Perhaps. But will these stories make us feel more connected to humanity, more seen and heard? Will AI stories cheapen the worth of writers? The answer is, who still cares about it?

As AI comes to media, in its current form, I see it as a decent assistant to creators. Maybe a writer with his or her AI tools, or a graphic designer powered by intelligent engines, will be able to do wonders. Lots of AI engineers view (or market) these tools as 'co-pilots'. Maybe the term also gives them a non-threatening sheen. But as far as replacing storytellers is concerned, I still wonder whether writing a story and creating beautiful worlds requires less of a human touch than, say, serving a glass of water on set. Or, are we even 'human' human anymore if, in our stories, we refuse to embrace our humanness, honesty, flaws and awkwardness? ■